Dred Scott v. Sandford

Chief Justice Roger B. Taney, for the Court · March 6, 1857

Source: Dred Scott v. Sandford (1857). Public domain. The Court's central holdings.

> The Supreme Court ruled that African Americans could not be citizens and that Congress had no power to bar slavery from the territories, striking down the Missouri Compromise. The decision inflamed sectional tensions and pushed the nation toward civil war.

They had for more than a century before been regarded as beings of an inferior order, and altogether unfit to associate with the white race either in social or political relations, and so far inferior that they had no rights which the white man was bound to respect, and that the negro might justly and lawfully be reduced to slavery for his benefit.

[. . .]

It is the opinion of the Court that the act of Congress which prohibited a citizen from holding and owning property of this kind in the territory of the United States north of the line therein mentioned [the Missouri Compromise] is not warranted by the Constitution, and is therefore void, and that neither Dred Scott himself nor any of his family were made free by being carried into this territory.